General rule – areas of effect and line of sight · "Spells" chapter of SRD 5.2.1

A spell or effect can affect an **area**: **Cone**, **Cube**, **Cylinder**, **Emanation**, **Line** or **Sphere**. The area has a **point of origin**. The effect doesn't pass through obstacles: you need a **line of effect** (no Total Cover) between origin and target.

A **line of sight** is needed to target a creature you must **see**. **Total Cover** blocks both line of sight and line of effect.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Find the area's **point of origin**.
2. Measure the shape: range, radius, length.
3. Check the **line of effect**: no Total Cover.
4. Creatures in the area suffer the effect.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 adds the **Emanation** shape and clarifies the area follows line of effect from the origin.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The exact shape (cone, cube) can be ambiguous on a grid. Fix: round to squares and announce the choice.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the shape of the blast or breath so the area feels intuitive.

Step 1 – Choose the origin:

A point you can see within the spell's range (or yourself for an Emanation).

Step 2 – Draw the shape:

Cone: width equals distance. Cube: origin on a face. Sphere: origin at the center.

Step 3 – Check line of effect:

A creature with Total Cover from the origin isn't affected.

Step 4 – Count the targets:

Every creature in the area (even allies) suffers the effect, unless stated otherwise.

Step 5 – Apply:

Save or damage: cover may give +2 or +5 to Dexterity saves.

Example: Elora casts Fireball (20 ft radius) behind a wall: creatures on the far side have no line of effect, so they aren't hit.

Shape	Rule
Cone	Width = distance from origin; the origin isn't part of it.
Cube	Given side length; origin on a face.
Cylinder	Radius and height; origin at the circle's center (top or bottom).
Emanation	Starts from the creature; the area follows it; the creature isn't affected unless stated.
Line	Given length, width 5 ft by default.
Sphere	Radius from a point of origin, at the center.

⚠ Common questions:

Is the caster in their own area?

Only if the area includes them (Emanation: no, unless stated).

Do allies take damage?

Yes, any creature in the area.

What is line of effect?

A path without Total Cover between origin and target.

Is a cone centered on me?

No: it starts from a point, often you, but excludes that point.

Does a wall corner stop the effect?

Yes: the effect only goes around openings.

Must I see the target?

Only if the spell says so ("a creature you can see").

Diagonal measuring?

Yes, at true distance; on a grid, a diagonal counts as 5 ft.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Grid or tape?

Diagonals on a grid. **Option**: 5 ft per square, diagonals included.

Area and hiding

Does an area hit a hidden creature? **Option**: yes, if it has no Total Cover.

Origin on a creature

Follows its movement. **Option**: keep it.

Sphere and height

A 3D sphere: **Option**: height matters.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Line of effect

The area stops at obstacles; it only goes around openings.

Emanation

It starts from the creature and follows it; the creature isn't included.

Origin

The origin point must be visible, not necessarily on a creature.

Cover

Cover protects based on the effect's origin position.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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